

# ZTA Grading Guide

How to grade each team's solution and place it at a level — **Associate**, **Professional** or **Expert**. Rubric, the expected answer at each level, and a score + feedback sheet per use case. The reference answers live in the **ZTA Solution Guide**. **Do not show participants.**

**How scoring works.** Each use case = **100 points** (Mapping 40 / Products 30 / Diagram 30). Grade against the reference answer (Solution Guide), decide a level per criterion, assign points, then total → overall level. Award partial credit generously; reward Cisco differentiators.

## The three levels

### Associate 60–74

Foundational: identifies the right general Cisco products and meets the basic requirement, but light on *how* and *why*.

### Professional 75–89

Solid, correct design: pains mapped to the right products with a clear how & why and a Cisco differentiator; enforcement points shown.

### Expert 90–100

Comprehensive & differentiated: every pain/requirement mapped precisely, multiple differentiators, flows traced end-to-end.

Below Associate = **Developing (< 60)**: incomplete or largely incorrect.

## How to grade

1. Read the team's three answer areas against the reference answer for the use case (see the Solution Guide).
2. For each criterion pick a **level** (Associate / Professional / Expert) using the rubric and assign **points** in that band.
3. Total to a **/100** score → the team's **level** for that use case.
4. Write **feedback**: one strength and one concrete improvement; name products.
5. The team's **overall level** = average of submitted use cases (required 1–3; bonus can raise it).

## Rubric — criteria × level

| CRITERION                    | MAX | ASSOCIATE                                                                                            | PROFESSIONAL                                                                                  | EXPERT                                                                                                 |
|------------------------------|-----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Pain-point → product mapping | 40  | <b>20–27</b><br>Maps the main pain points to broadly correct products; some gaps or generic choices. | <b>28–34</b><br>Maps all pain points to the correct Cisco products, each with a clear reason. | <b>35–40</b><br>Every pain mapped precisely to the optimal product with strong justification; no gaps. |

| CRITERION                                         | MAX | ASSOCIATE                                                                                          | PROFESSIONAL                                                                                           | EXPERT                                                                                                                |
|---------------------------------------------------|-----|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Products — how &amp; why / differentiators</b> | 30  | <b>15–20</b><br>Names products; explains “how” only partially; few or no differentiators.          | <b>21–26</b><br>Correct “how” for each product and a real “why”; at least one Cisco differentiator.    | <b>27–30</b><br>Precise “how” + compelling “why” for every product; multiple Cisco differentiators vs competitors.    |
| <b>Diagram &amp; overall solution</b>             | 30  | <b>15–20</b><br>Diagram present and legible; labels groups; enforcement points partial or unclear. | <b>21–26</b><br>Labels groups, marks enforcement points; solution coherent and meets the requirements. | <b>27–30</b><br>Traces flow(s) end-to-end with policy/matrix detail; considers integration/edge cases; within budget. |

### Overall level by score

| LEVEL        | SCORE  | MEANING                                                                                                                     |
|--------------|--------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| DEVELOPING   | < 60   | Incomplete or largely incorrect — missing core products or misunderstands the requirement.                                  |
| ASSOCIATE    | 60–74  | Foundational: right general products, meets the basic requirement; light on how/why.                                        |
| PROFESSIONAL | 75–89  | Solid, correct design: pains mapped with clear how/why and a Cisco differentiator; enforcement points shown.                |
| EXPERT       | 90–100 | Comprehensive & differentiated: every pain/requirement mapped precisely, multiple differentiators, flows traced end-to-end. |

# Use Case 1 — Managed Environment — Segmentation

Required

100 pts

Segment campus & branch wired/wireless clients into groups (Employees, IOT, deskagents, Guest) and control what each can reach. Pains: VLAN/subnet complexity, labour-intensive profiling, failing PCI, PCs behind on AV/OS, no budget for more firewalls.

## Expected answer by level

| LEVEL        | WHAT A SOLUTION AT THIS LEVEL CONTAINS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ASSOCIATE    | Chooses Cisco <b>ISE</b> and <b>SGTs</b> over VLANs/subnets and assigns the four groups (Employees, IOT, deskagents, Guest). Shows the basic intent to restrict IoT and Guest. Light on how the SGT matrix is built; may omit ISE Posture (AV/OS) or the PCI L7 nuance.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| PROFESSIONAL | Maps every pain to the right product: <b>ISE profiling</b> (onboarding), <b>SGTs/SGACL</b> enforced on the existing switches (no new firewalls), <b>ISE Posture</b> for AV/OS remediation, and <b>FTD/FW inserted only where L7</b> is needed for PCI. Defines correct SGT-matrix rules (IoT → DC+Internet only; Guest → Internet only; Mac-mini → on-prem DC only) and cites a Cisco differentiator (SGACL more efficient / topology-independent). Diagram marks enforcement points.                                |
| EXPERT       | All of Professional, plus an end-to-end story: <b>pxGrid / Rapid Threat Containment</b> , <b>Cisco Secure Workload</b> App Dependency Mapping for DC app segmentation, dynamic vs static SGT assignment and <b>ISE cloud-AI profiling</b> , and integration across switches/routers/FTD/SD-WAN. Diagram traces at least one flow end-to-end (e.g. IoT → DC permit, IoT → Employees deny) and inserts FTD only where L7/PCI requires it. Clearly argues why Cisco (end-to-end SGT, RFC8600 pxGrid) beats competitors. |

## Score & level

| CRITERION                  | LEVEL (CIRCLE ONE)                                                                                                               | POINTS                     |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------|
| Pain → product mapping     | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          | <input type="text"/> / 40  |
| Products — how & why       | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          | <input type="text"/> / 30  |
| Diagram & overall solution | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          | <input type="text"/> / 30  |
| Total & level              | <input type="radio"/> Developing <input type="radio"/> Associate <input type="radio"/> Professional <input type="radio"/> Expert | <input type="text"/> / 100 |

## Feedback

✓ What the team did well

▲ Where they can improve

# Use Case 2 — Remote Workers — Zero Trust Access

Required

100 pts

SASE for remote workers & branches. Requirements: ZTNA for modern apps (VPN only for legacy), block gambling/gaming, contractors clientless RDP, minimal sign-ons, SASE branches. Pains: over-permissive VPN, manual daily VPN, too many sign-ons, kill passwords, Okta too costly, reduce branch cost.

## Expected answer by level

| LEVEL        | WHAT A SOLUTION AT THIS LEVEL CONTAINS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|--------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ASSOCIATE    | Recognizes ZTNA over full VPN and proposes <b>Cisco Secure Access</b> with the <b>Secure Client ZTA module</b> ; mentions SSO and blocking gambling/gaming. Light on how per-app tunnels, Duo Passport, passwordless, or SASE integration actually work.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| PROFESSIONAL | Maps pains correctly: <b>ZTA module</b> (per-app, least-privilege) for modern apps with full VPN kept only for legacy; <b>SWG</b> to block gambling/gaming; <b>browser-only clientless</b> access for contractors; <b>Duo Passport SSO + advanced passwordless</b> ; <b>Duo Directory</b> to replace costly Okta; <b>SD-WAN into Secure Access</b> for SASE. Explains why ZTNA beats full VPN.                                                                                                                                                         |
| EXPERT       | All of Professional with the full Secure Access story and Cisco-unique points: <b>Private Resources proxy</b> (publish apps to VPN/ZTA/browser), <b>VPNaaS mapping VPN traffic to SGTs</b> for segmentation (unique to Cisco), <b>Unified Policy</b> for public+private resources, and <b>SD-WAN → Secure Access via IPsec + Direct Internet Access</b> . Diagram shows the SSE enforcement plane and per-user paths (employee/contractor/guest) with identity via Duo. Argues why Duo Passport/passwordless and Cisco SASE win over Okta/competitors. |

## Score & level

| CRITERION                  | LEVEL (CIRCLE ONE)                                                                                                               | POINTS                     |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------|
| Pain → product mapping     | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          | <input type="text"/> / 40  |
| Products — how & why       | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          | <input type="text"/> / 30  |
| Diagram & overall solution | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          | <input type="text"/> / 30  |
| Total & level              | <input type="radio"/> Developing <input type="radio"/> Associate <input type="radio"/> Professional <input type="radio"/> Expert | <input type="text"/> / 100 |

## Feedback

✓ What the team did well

▲ Where they can improve

# Use Case 3 — AI Access and Agent Controls

Required

100 pts

Report and guardrail AI usage from Use Case 2. Requirements: fine-grained tool control, corporate ChatGPT tenant only, control Claude Desktop agents, govern MCP servers (Claude Code). Pains: shadow AI, unknown/over-privileged MCP servers, personal ChatGPT credentials, risky model downloads.

## Expected answer by level

| LEVEL        | WHAT A SOLUTION AT THIS LEVEL CONTAINS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ASSOCIATE    | Understands the shadow-AI risk and proposes <b>Secure Access AI Access</b> for visibility/control; mentions restricting ChatGPT to the corporate tenant. Light on MCP-server governance, agent registration, or model inspection.                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| PROFESSIONAL | Maps pains: <b>Secure Access AI Access</b> (discover/control), <b>AI Gateway</b> to register/manage allowed MCP servers, <b>tenant controls</b> to force the corporate ChatGPT tenant and block personal logins, and <b>semantic inspection</b> to block risky models. Adds <b>Duo IdP</b> for fine-grained authorization and control of Claude Desktop agents.                                                                           |
| EXPERT       | All of Professional plus agentic depth: <b>Duo IdP agent registration (DCR)</b> governing what registered desktop agents and MCP integrations (Claude Code) may do, <b>DLP via Secure Access + Cisco AI Defense</b> to stop sensitive-data exposure across endpoint/cloud/web, and a clear per-identity fine-grained policy model. Argues why Cisco's AI Gateway + Duo integration is easier and more complete than IdP-only competitors. |

## Score & level

| CRITERION                  | LEVEL (CIRCLE ONE)                                                                                                               | POINTS                     |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------|
| Pain → product mapping     | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          | <input type="text"/> / 40  |
| Products — how & why       | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          | <input type="text"/> / 30  |
| Diagram & overall solution | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          | <input type="text"/> / 30  |
| Total & level              | <input type="radio"/> Developing <input type="radio"/> Associate <input type="radio"/> Professional <input type="radio"/> Expert | <input type="text"/> / 100 |

## Feedback

✓ What the team did well

▲ Where they can improve

# Use Case 4 — Merger & Acquisition — Extend Segmentation

Bonus

100 pts

Integrate a ~100-staff acquisition fast. Remote site has Cisco FTD (Internet edge + AI-cluster segmenting); acquired co uses Okta. Requirements: extend TrustSec segmentation, only selected users reach Site 9951. Pains: how to extend segmentation, don't want to onboard 100 users, minimize auth disruption, breached/passwords.

## Expected answer by level

| LEVEL        | WHAT A SOLUTION AT THIS LEVEL CONTAINS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ASSOCIATE    | Proposes extending <b>TrustSec/SGTs</b> to the acquired site and using <b>Duo</b> for the acquired users; basic idea to restrict Site 9951. Light on inline SGT tagging over the S2S VPN, SCIM import, or SSO routing.                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| PROFESSIONAL | Maps pains: <b>inline SGT tagging on the remote FTD over a site-to-site VPN</b> to extend segmentation from HQ; <b>source/destination SGTs</b> in the FTD policy to restrict Site 9951 to selected users; <b>Duo Directory + SCIM import from Okta</b> (no bulk corporate-directory onboarding); <b>Duo SSO routing</b> so Okta keeps working during transition; <b>Duo passwordless</b> for the breached users. |
| EXPERT       | All of Professional plus <b>SCC pushing SGT policy into SD-WAN</b> (match source branch SGT to destination acquisition FTD), a clean migration path off Okta, and the Cisco differentiators of inline SGT tagging + Duo's easy multi-IdP integration. Diagram shows the S2S tunnel, extended SGTs, the restricted Site 9951 flow, and Duo directory/SSO federation.                                              |

## Score & level

| CRITERION                  | LEVEL (CIRCLE ONE)                                                                                                               | POINTS                     |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------|
| Pain → product mapping     | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          | <input type="text"/> / 40  |
| Products — how & why       | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          | <input type="text"/> / 30  |
| Diagram & overall solution | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          | <input type="text"/> / 30  |
| Total & level              | <input type="radio"/> Developing <input type="radio"/> Associate <input type="radio"/> Professional <input type="radio"/> Expert | <input type="text"/> / 100 |

## Feedback

✓ What the team did well

▲ Where they can improve

# Use Case 5 — Zero Trust across Multicloud Data Center

Bonus

100 pts

Application sprawl across on-prem/AWS/Azure; discover apps (incl. Kubernetes), minimize blast radius, app run-time protection. Requirements: limited budget/native features/virtual appliances, end-to-end segmentation, minimize complexity. Pains: no app visibility, no segmentation plan, K8s latency/visibility, can't patch IoT, too many disparate consoles.

## Expected answer by level

| LEVEL        | WHAT A SOLUTION AT THIS LEVEL CONTAINS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|--------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ASSOCIATE    | Proposes <b>Cisco Secure Workload</b> to discover and segment applications across on-prem/AWS/Azure and mentions minimizing blast radius. Light on Kubernetes runtime, auto-baseline policy, or unified management.                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| PROFESSIONAL | Maps pains: <b>Secure Workload App Dependency Mapping</b> for visibility and <b>auto-baseline microsegmentation</b> (discover → validate → enforce); <b>Isovalent (Cilium/eBPF, Tetragon)</b> for Kubernetes observability and runtime protection; <b>Cisco Cloud Control (SCC)</b> to unify the many management interfaces; leverages native cloud features and <b>FTDv virtual appliances</b> for budget.                           |
| EXPERT       | All of Professional plus the end-to-end policy story: <b>ISE common policy sharing identity/SGT context via pxGrid</b> to Secure Workload and FTD; <b>CSW ↔ FTDv policy sync</b> ; kernel-level protection via <b>eBPF</b> as the runtime differentiator; and a coherent multicloud enforcement design that minimizes complexity and blast radius. Argues why Cisco's CSW+FTD+Isovalent integration beats native-only or point tools. |

## Score & level

| CRITERION                  | LEVEL (CIRCLE ONE)                                                                                                               | POINTS                     |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------|
| Pain → product mapping     | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          | <input type="text"/> / 40  |
| Products — how & why       | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          | <input type="text"/> / 30  |
| Diagram & overall solution | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          | <input type="text"/> / 30  |
| Total & level              | <input type="radio"/> Developing <input type="radio"/> Associate <input type="radio"/> Professional <input type="radio"/> Expert | <input type="text"/> / 100 |

## Feedback

✓ What the team did well

▲ Where they can improve

## Team summary

| USE CASE                                         | TRACK                  | SCORE /100                  | LEVEL                                                                                                                            |
|--------------------------------------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| UC1 — Managed Environment — Segmentation         | Required               | <input type="text"/>        | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          |
| UC2 — Remote Workers — Zero Trust Access         | Required               | <input type="text"/>        | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          |
| UC3 — AI Access and Agent Controls               | Required               | <input type="text"/>        | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          |
| UC4 — Merger & Acquisition — Extend Segmentation | Bonus                  | <input type="text"/>        | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          |
| UC5 — Zero Trust across Multicloud Data Center   | Bonus                  | <input type="text"/>        | <input type="radio"/> A <input type="radio"/> P <input type="radio"/> E                                                          |
| Overall                                          | Required 1–3 (+ bonus) | <input type="text"/><br>avg | <input type="radio"/> Developing <input type="radio"/> Associate <input type="radio"/> Professional <input type="radio"/> Expert |

### Overall feedback

✓ What the team did well

▲ Where they can improve

Proctor:  · Team:  · Date: